Whenever it has been in power in the state, the BJP has the habit of making frequent changes in the top leadership. Between 2008 and 2013, it had three chief ministers—Yediyurappa, D.V. Sadananda Gowda and Jagadish Shettar. In the 2018 election, the BJP won only 104 seats and had to sit in the Opposition for a year because the Congress and the JD(S) formed a post-poll coalition. After it formed a government in July the following year by engineering defections from the rival parties, the BJP has had two chief ministers—Yediyurappa and Bommai.

Though the BJP has not formally announced a CM candidate so far, Bommai supporters believe that in the event of a victory, he will be the party's natural choice. Bommai belongs to the Lingayat community, which makes up 17 per cent of the electorate and wields influence across 70 constituencies. Yediyurappa, too, is a Lingayat and is considered one of its most prominent leaders. When Yediyurappa was told to step down as CM (he claims that he volunteered to do so as he was pushing 80), one of the major reasons the party chose Bommai as his replacement was to ensure that the Lingayat vote stayed with the BJP.

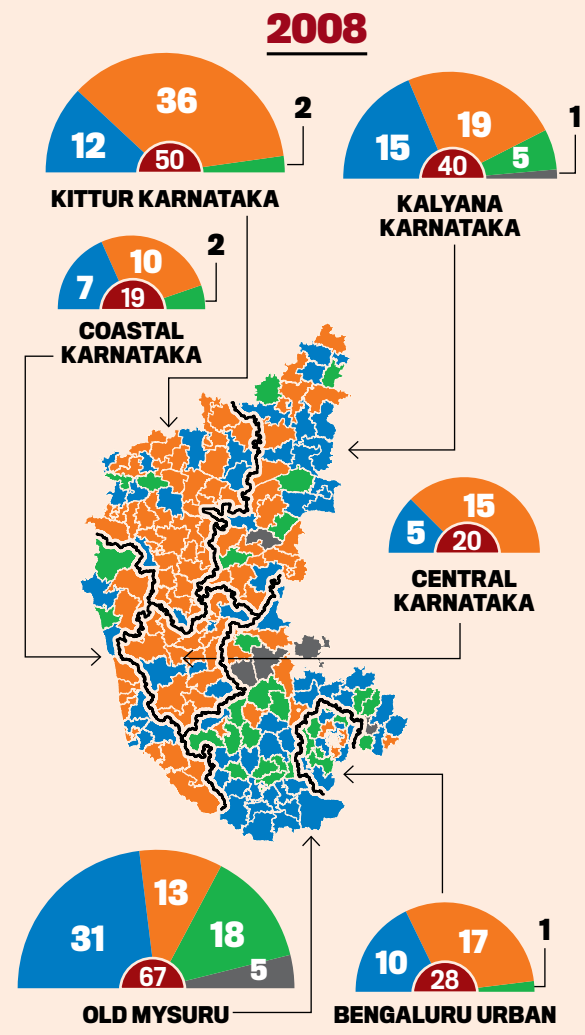
"A fierce battle is on," says Chief Minister Basavaraj Bommai. "While for the Congress, it's a do-or-die battle, for the BJP, it is a must-win"

Bommai supporters point to two other indications. Union home minister Amit Shah, who is overseeing the campaign strategy, had said that the election would be fought under Bommai's leadership. BJP president J.P. Nadda felt that since Bommai had been given less than two years to lead, he should be given some more years to rule if the party wins. As one of Bommai's aides put it, "The direction of the wind is clearly in favour of the CM." Yet, as an election strategy, the party has not openly announced a CM nominee yet. It has good reason to keep its leadership cards close to its chest. So does the Congress, which has to sort out the leadership tangle between Siddaramaiah and D.K. Shivakumar, the president of the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC).

THE CONGRESS MAKEOVER

Ever since Shivakumar took over as KPCC chief in 2020, its headquarters on Queen's Road has undergone a complete makeover. The building now has an imposing Greco-Roman façade and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi recently inaugurated a swank annexe called the Bharat Jodo Bhavan, which boasts a massive auditorium as well as state-of-the-art communication facilities. The Congress seems confident of regaining power in the state after a hiatus of four years and is pushing hard to ensure it does so with a comfortable majority. Inside the party's war room, Gaurav Vallabh, the party's strategist and national spokesperson, has scribbled 140+ seats on a white board to indicate the number of seats the party is expecting to win. On his smartphone, Vallabh accesses the website of a local paper, which has a daily tracker. On that day, it shows that

SIX REGIONS THAT MATTER



CASTE MATH

Major caste groups in Karnataka
(% of state's population)

